

Fearsome mounted archers
14th-century Mongol horsemen depicted in battle *(above)* with their composite bows and tough, sturdy mounts. Mongol helmets were often peaked, a variation on the Steppe nomad's peaked felt cap. This late Mongolian-period Nogai Horde helmet *(right)* is from the Caucasus Mountain region, a remnant of the Mongol invasion of Eurasia.

NOMADIC HORSEMEN from the Asian steppe, the Mongols established one of the world's largest ever land empires in the 13th century. After the traditionally warring steppe tribes united under the leadership of Genghis Khan, they launched campaigns of conquest westwards into the Middle East and Europe, and eastwards to China's Pacific coast. The armies of the settled civilizations of Eurasia were overwhelmed time and again by the speed of movement, aggression, and fighting skills of the all-conquering Mongols.

Before the rise of Temujin, later known as Genghis Khan, the Mongols were merely one among many Turkic tribes living in the tough environment of the steppe north of the Gobi desert. These tent-dwelling horsemen had mostly entered recorded history as raiders and invaders threatening the towns and cities of northern China. The steppe tribes were constantly at war with one another until, in 1206, they recognized Mongol leader Temujin as their khan (Genghis Khan means "lord of the earth"). Genghis and his successors were able to direct the energies of the tribal horsemen outwards and transform raiders into conquerors.

TOUGH FIGHTERS

The Mongols lived all their lives in a close relationship with their tough horses. It was said that a Mongol boy learned to ride before he could walk. As well as a horseman, every Mongol male was a hunter and a warrior. From an early age he was taught the use of the composite bow, a powerful weapon made of horn, wood, and sinew. He took part in the large mounted hunting parties that the steppe tribes employed to encircle and kill game, thus acquiring practice in coordination and manoeuvre that would serve him well in later battles. The Mongol warrior honed his fighting skills in local tribal wars and his survival skills in the hard life of the steppe.

Composed of such men, Genghis's armies were highly mobile, campaigning over distances of thousands of kilometres. They were capable of living off the land for long periods even in the most inhospitable terrain, and so were not slowed down by a supply train. The horsemen existed on a diet of dried meat and fermented mare's milk, augmented at times by fresh horse's blood. Since each warrior had a string of four or five mounts, he could continually change horses and thus keep moving over long distances day after day. Rivers were no obstacle to a Mongol campaign: the men would undress, stow their clothes in a waterproof bag, and swim across with their horses. The warrior's weaponry was usually light. Most were mounted archers who would carry two or three bows and a couple of quivers of arrows. A thoroughly self-reliant man, the warrior carried a sharpening stone for his weapons and a needle and thread for running repairs to his clothing and leather armour.

RUTHLESS VICTORS

The Mongols used their great mobility to find, fix, and destroy enemy forces. They were ferocious fighting men, but in no sense a disorganized horde. Each warrior belonged to a group of ten (an *arban*), itself part of a group of 100, 1,000, and 10,000. The army was well officered, with higher appointments made by the khan and lower officers chosen by their men. In practice this amounted to promotion by merit. Small units could operate with great independence, but the Mongol commanders were also capable of coordinating large-scale forces on the battlefield, using smoke signals, trumpets, and banners to communicate orders.



NOGAI HORDE HELMET